Install GitHub Desktop

Please complete this before class on Thursday, 15 October 2026.

You only need to follow ONE set of instructions: Windows OR Mac. Use your own laptop or desktop computer.

GitHub Desktop is a free program we will use in class.

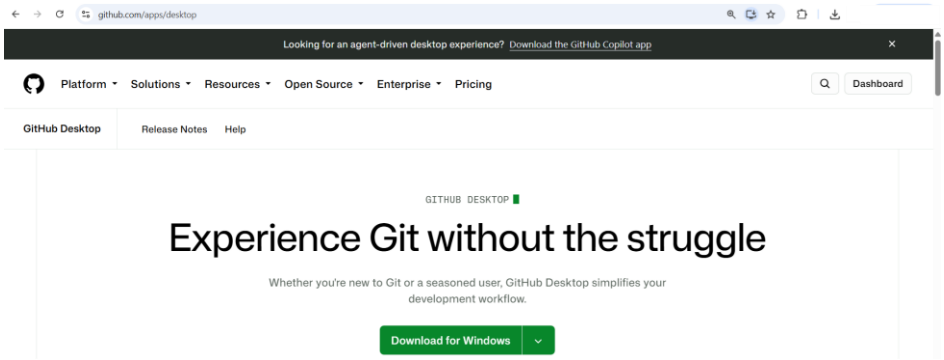
Part A - Windows laptop or PC

1. Open your internet browser

Click Chrome, Edge or another browser (the app you use to visit websites).

2. Go to the official website

Type desktop.github.com in the address box for the browser and press Enter on your keyboard.



3. Download the Windows version

Click “Download for Windows” or “Download for Windows (64bit)”. Wait for the file to finish downloading.

4. Find the downloaded file

Open File Explorer (the yellow folder on the taskbar). Select “Downloads” on the left. Look for a file named similar to GitHubDesktopSetup.exe.

5. Run the installer

Double-click the setup file (press the left mouse button twice quickly). If Windows asks for confirmation, check that it says GitHub Desktop, then follow the on-screen prompt.

6. Wait for GitHub Desktop to open

The installation may take a minute or two. When the GitHub Desktop window appears, the installation is complete. Do not worry if it asks you to sign in; see Part C.

Note: If you cannot find the Downloads folder, press Windows key + E to open File Explorer, then click Downloads.

Part B - Apple Mac / MacBook



1. Open Safari or Chrome

Click the Safari compass icon or the Chrome icon. These programs let you open websites.



2. Go to the official website

Type desktop.github.com in the address box, and press Return on your keyboard.



3. Find out which Mac you have

Click the Apple symbol at the top-left of the screen, then “About This Mac”. Look for “Chip” or “Processor”. If it says Apple M1, M2, M3, M4, M5 (or similar), choose Apple silicon. If it says Intel, choose Intel.



4. Download the correct Mac version

On the GitHub Desktop website, click “Download for Apple silicon” or “Download for Intel chip” to match Step 3. Wait for the download to finish.



5. Open Downloads

Click Finder (the blue smiling face on the Dock). On the left, click “Downloads”. You can also use the Downloads icon near the Dock.



6. Unzip the downloaded file

Find the GitHub Desktop .zip file. Double-click it once (two quick clicks) to extract it. A GitHub Desktop application file should appear.



7. Open GitHub Desktop

Double-click the GitHub Desktop application. If your Mac asks whether to open an app downloaded from the internet, check the app name and choose “Open”.



8. Check that it opens

A GitHub Desktop window should appear. You may also drag the app into your Applications folder to keep it there for future classes.

Part C - Check you are ready

You do not need to create a project or learn the buttons yet. We will do that together in class.



1. Open GitHub Desktop again

Windows: open Start and type “GitHub Desktop”, then click it.

Mac: open Finder -> Applications -> GitHub Desktop



2. If a sign-in screen appears

That is normal. If you already have a GitHub account, you may sign in with it using college gmail address (sba00000@student.cct.ie). If you face any issue, we eill discuss in the next class.



3. Check the result

If the GitHub Desktop window opens without an error message, you are ready for Thursday class.

References

- https://desktop.github.com/download/
- OpenAI. (2026). ChatGPT. OpenAI (CCT Licensed Version).